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Does the Community Understand the Community Guidelines?

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ABSTRACT

Amid continued public controversy and political debate about online speech governments and civil society have pushed social media platforms to increase transparency around how they regulate speech, through community guidelines and content moderation systems, to support users to hold companies accountable for content removals. But how well do users understand apply platform content rules? We report results of two complementary studies. In Study 1, lab participants were randomly assigned to judge whether posts violated the guidelines of 10 platforms. Users' interpretations of the guidelines were inconsistent with each other, especially for platforms with longer documents. In Study 2, we preregistered an experiment testing whether shortened versions of Meta's guidelines improved understanding. Reducing length without simplifying moderation rules did not lower disagreement about what content the platform moderates. Taken together, our results indicate substantial room to improve the interpretability of community guidelines, enabling users to evaluate moderation more reliably. These findings highlight design tradeoffs and motivate clearer, example-driven guidance.

1 | Introduction

Content moderation was once a purely behind-the-scenes process, managed largely by engineers, outsourced moderators, the occasional flaggers, and internal policy teams at major tech companies. However, as social media platforms have gained more power over what can be discussed in the public sphere, moderation is now at the center of political discourse and public controversy, debated by lawmakers, invoked in partisan arguments, and closely tied to broader concerns about democratic accountability and free expression. Governments, civil society, and users increasingly push back against opaque or inconsistently enforced rules that are often seen as arbitrary or lacking legitimacy (Kemp and Ekins 2021; Stohl et al. 2016). Liberal and conservative commentators alike now accuse platforms of overreach or bias, and questions of what content gets

removed, and why (Appel et al. 2023; Corduneanu-Huci and Hamilton 2022). Users across the political spectrum are generally unsatisfied with platform moderation rules—some claim the rules are too lax, others too strict, and still others believe the standards are selectively applied (Suzor 2019).

Both governments and civil society have pushed platforms to increase their transparency to facilitate more accountability.¹ In response, many platforms have released increasingly detailed content moderation guidelines—or “community guidelines”—that aim to define what content will be removed from their websites (Katzenbach et al. 2023; Nahrgang et al. 2025; Schaffner et al. 2024; Singhal et al. 2023). “Community guidelines,” whose content varies significantly across platforms, signal commitments to fairness, openness, and due process, and

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